

Session 27: The Founding of Babylon

Key Takeaways

- The building of the tower links thematically to the rejection of God's provision and deliverance.
- Acts plays out a revision and reversal of the scattering at the tower of Babylon.

The Founding of Babylon: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 11:1-9

¹ Now **all the land** was
one language
and unified words

² and it came about as they journeyed east,
that they found a plain in the land of **Shinar**
and they settled there.

Babylon's Two Speeches

³ **And they said** each to **his neighbor** ,
“ **Come** , let us brick bricks and burn them as burnt.”
and for them, the brick was like stone,
and tar was for them like mortar.

⁴ **And they said** ,
“ **Come** , let us **build for ourselves a city** ,
and **a tower** whose head is in the skies,
and let us **make for ourselves a name** ,
lest we be scattered upon the face of all the land.”

Yahweh “Comes Down”

⁵ **And Yahweh came down** to see **the city and the tower**
that the sons of humanity **built** .

Yahweh's Two Statements

6 **And Yahweh said** ,
 a “ **Behold** , **one people** ,
 a' and **one language** for all of them
 b and this they have begun to do,
 c and now, nothing will be inaccessible for them,
 b' anything that they devise to do.
 7 **Come** , let us go down
 and **let us make-babble of** **their language** there,
 so that each one will not hear the **language** of **his neighbor** .”

a 8 And Yahweh **scattered them from there upon the face of** **all the land** ,
 b and they stopped **building** the **city** .
 b' 9 Therefore, its **name** was called **Babylon** ,
 b' because there Yahweh **made-babble of** **the language of** **all the land** ,
 a' and from there Yahweh **scattered them upon the face of** **all the land** .

Genesis 11:1-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Features of This Literary Design

- The opening and closing scenes focus on the location and language of this endeavor. Shinar/Babylon are juxtaposed, while the unified language is contrasted with the confused languages at the conclusion.
- The double speech panel of the Babylonians (vv. 3-4) is matched by the double speech of Yahweh (vv. 6-7). Their initiative begins with a joint endeavor between neighbors (v. 3) and leads to the construction of a city for their own name, along with a tower that elevates them to the realm of the gods (v. 4). Yahweh’s speech addresses each of these in reverse: first their aspirations (v. 6), and then their language that makes this “neighborly” endeavor possible (v. 7).
- At the center of the unit is Yahweh’s “descent” to investigate the city and tower.

Babylon, Eden’s Exile, and Cain’s City

The founding of Babylon is filled with hyperlinks back to the story of humanity’s exile from Eden and to the building of Cain’s city.

Eden

Genesis 3:22-23 NASB*

22 And Yahweh Elohim said, “**Behold** (הן), the human has become **like one of us**, knowing good and bad, **and now** (ועתה), so that he doesn’t stretch out his hand, and take also from the tree of life, and eat, and live forever.”

23 And **Yahweh God sent him out** from the garden of Eden, to cultivate the ground from which he was taken.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 3:24 NASB*

And [Yahweh] banished the human and he stationed **from the east** of the garden of Eden cherubim and the flaming sword

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Babylon

Genesis 11:6-8 NASB*

⁶ And Yahweh said, “**Behold** (הִנֵּה), they are one people, and they all have the same language, and this is what they began to do, **and now** (וְעַתָּה) nothing they purpose to do will be impossible for them.

⁷ Come, **let us go down** and there confuse their language so that they will not understand one another’s speech.”

⁸ And **Yahweh scattered them abroad** from there over the face of the whole earth, and they stopped building the city.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 11:2 NASB*

And it came about as they journeyed **from the east** ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Babylon is also thematically linked to Cain’s city in Genesis 4:17 and Nimrod’s city in Genesis 10:8-10.

City	Reference	Connections
Cain’s City	4:17 And Cain knew his wife and she conceived, and gave birth to Enoch; and he built a city , and called the name of the city Enoch, according to the name of his son.	• Cain builds a city for self-protection after exile from the high Eden land • He names the city after his own family lineage
Nimrod’s City	10:8 Now, Cush became the father of Nimrod; he began to be a mighty warrior in the land. ⁹ He was a mighty warrior-hunter before Yahweh; therefore it is said, “ Like Nimrod a mighty warrior-hunter	• Nimrod’s name is praised and repeated • His kingdom begins in Babylon and Shinar • He builds Nineveh, a great city

Babylon Cities. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

City	Reference	Connections
	before Yahweh.” ¹⁰ And the beginning of his kingdom was Babylon and Erech and Accad and Calneh, in the land of Shinar . ¹¹ From that land he went forth into Assyria, and he built Nineveh and Rehoboth-Ir and Calah, ¹² and Resen between Nineveh and Calah; that is the great city .	
Babylon's City	11:4 and they said, “Come, let us build for ourselves a city , and a tower whose head will be in the skies, and let us make for ourselves a name , lest we be scattered upon the face of all the land.” ⁹ Therefore its name was called Babylon	• Babylonians build a city • They seek to elevate their name
<i>Babylon Cities.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).		

All the Land Had “One Language”

The phrase “all the land” is a reference back to the offspring of the sons of Noah in Genesis 9:19.

Genesis 9:18-19 NASB*

¹⁸ Now the sons of Noah who came out of the ark were Shem and Ham and Japheth; and Ham was the father of Canaan. ¹⁹ These three were the sons of Noah, and from these **all the land was scattered**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“One language” (Heb. *saphah* ‘ekhat) and “unified words” (Heb. *devarim* ‘ekhadim)

“Unified” (אחדים) is the plural of the word “one” (אחד). It can be used to mean “few” when applied to a small group of something (a “few days” as in Gen. 27:44, 29:20; Dan. 11:20). But when it describes multiple things becoming one, it means unified.

Ezekiel 37:16-17 NASB*

¹⁶ And you, son of man, take for yourself **one** stick and write on it, "For Judah and for the sons of Israel, his companions." Then take **one** stick and write on it, "For Joseph, the stick of Ephraim and all the house of Israel, his companions." ¹⁷ Then join them for yourself **one** to **one** into **one** stick, that they may become **unified** (אחדים) in your hand.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This example from Ezekiel illuminates what it means that "all the land" (i.e., the descendants of Noah's three sons) has "one lip and unified words."

From One Language to Many

In Genesis 10, we learn that each regional network of families from Noah's sons has their own clans and languages and lands and nations.

Genesis 10:5 NASB*

From these the coastlands of the nations were separated into their lands, each according to his language (lit. "tongue" / לשון), according to their families, into their nations.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 10:20 NASB

These are the sons of Ham, according to their families, according to their languages (lit. "tongues" / לשון), by their lands, by their nations.

Genesis 10:31 NASB

These are the sons of Shem, according to their families, according to their languages (lit. "tongues" / לשון), by their lands, according to their nations.

But Genesis 11:1 begins by telling us that "all the land had one language (lit. "lip" / שפה) and unified words." How do these two details work together?

It's most likely that Genesis 10 and 11:1-9 are deliberately arranged in non-chronological order.

"The best explanation is that these materials have been intentionally dischronologized in order to arrange them thematically. The purpose of the arrangement is to highlight a 'spread of sin, spread of grace' theme throughout Genesis 1-11, which in turn is part of a larger creation-uncreation-recreation theme of the Pentateuch. The Table of Nations in its current location fulfills the divine command to 'be fruitful and multiply, and fill the earth' (9:1, reflecting also 1:28), and is therefore predominantly a positive appraisal of human dispersion. The sons of Noah were fulfilling their purpose by bringing God's blessing to fruition. Had it been placed after 11:1-9 the Table of Nations in Genesis 10 would of necessity be transformed into a sign of God's judgment. As these two units stand, the division of humanity and the multiplicity of languages are evaluated both positively (Gen. 10) and negatively (Gen. 11)."

Arnold, Bill (2008). [*Genesis \(New Cambridge Bible Commentary\)*](#). Cambridge University Press. 118.

The later portrayal of Babylon in Daniel is seen as a rebellious reversal attempt to yet again unify the many peoples and languages in allegiance to divine Babylon. Daniel 1-3 draws upon Genesis 11:1-9 in many deliberate ways.

Genesis 11:2: “They settled in the plain (בקעה) of Shinar (שנער)”

- Daniel 1:2: Nebuchadnezzar plunders the Jerusalem temple and the royal seed of Judah and takes them to the “land of Shinar” (שנער).
- Daniel 2: Nebuchadnezzar dreams about an imperial image with a head of gold.
- Daniel 3:1: Nebuchadnezzar builds an image “in the plain (בקעה) of Dura.”

Genesis 11:1: “One language and unified words”

- Daniel 3:4: “To you the command is given, O peoples, nations, and languages” (cf. the clans, lands, languages, nations, of Gen. 10:5, 20, 31).

The Division of Languages in Ancient Cultural Context

Also important is the work of Samuel N. Kramer (“The ‘Babel of Tongues’: A Sumerian Version”), who noted an ancient Sumerian work called *Enmarker and the Lord of Aratta* (Kramer, 1968).

In those days,
there being no snakes,
there being no scorpions,
there being no hyenas,
there being no lions,
there being no dogs or wolves,
there being no (thing) fearful or hair-raising,
mankind had no opponents—

in those days ...
bilingual Sumer
being the great country
of princely office ...
(in) the (whole) compass
of heaven and earth
the people entrusted (to him)
could address Enlil,
verily, in but a single tongue.

In those days,
(having) periods of power,
princely and royal periods of power —
(did) Enki ... fight,
(150) did Enki, lord of abundance,
lord of effective command,
did the lord of intelligence,
the country's clever one ...
lord of Eridu
estrangle the tongues
in their mouths
as many as were put there.
The tongues of men
which were one.

Enmarker and the Lord of Aratta quoted in Hallo, William W. and Younger, K. Lawson (1997). [*The Context of Scripture, Volume 1: Canonical Compositions from the Biblical World*](#). Brill Academic Publishers. 547-548.

“On Kramer’s interpretation, the OT is offering an alternative explanation of the diversity of languages. Genesis is affirming that the diversity of languages represents a divine judgment on mankind and is not the product of rivalry between the gods Enlil and Enki. Here, as in the flood story, Genesis explains things in terms of a moral monotheism, whereas Mesopotamia saw things in terms of polytheistic competitiveness.”

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [*Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15*](#). Thomas Nelson. 237.

Babylon, Egypt, and Ancient Empire

The portrait of Babylon making a name for themselves through an ascent to the heavens becomes an icon of humanity's rebellion. Babylon is the first imperial rebel, and they set the pattern for later empires who will follow in the same footsteps.

In the book of Exodus, Egypt is set on analogy to Babylon through a sophisticated use of hyperlinks.

Plan and Response	Babylon in Genesis 11:3-4	Egypt in Exodus 1:10-11, 14
Humans concoct dastardly plans	³ They said to each other, “Come (הבה)”, let’s make bricks and bake them thoroughly.” They used brick (לבנה) instead of stone, and tar for mortar (חמר). ⁴ Then they said, “Come (הבה), let us build ourselves a city, with a tower that reaches to the heavens, so that we may make a name for ourselves, or else (פן) we will be scattered abroad over the face of the whole earth.”	¹⁰ Pharaoh said to his people, “Come (הבה), let us deal wisely with them, or else (פן) they will multiply and in the event of war, they will also join themselves to those who hate us, and fight against us and go up out of the land.” ¹¹ So they appointed taskmasters over them to afflict them with hard labor. And they built for Pharaoh storage cities, Pithom and Raamses ... ¹⁴ And they made their lives bitter with hard labor in mortar (חמר) and brick (לבנה) and at all kinds of labor in the field, all their labors which they rigorously imposed on them.
Yahweh turns evil plan back on itself	11:8 So Yahweh scattered them abroad from there over the face of the whole earth; and they stopped building the city.	13:18 And the people of Israel went up out of the land of Egypt equipped for battle. 14:25 And the Egyptians said, “Let us flee from before Israel, for Yahweh is fighting for them against the Egyptians.”
<i>Egypt is Set on Analogy to Babylon. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

"In a polemical vein, [the biblical author] named the Babylonian claim an instance of hubris and filed it in the incrementally growing catalog kept since the beginning of history. Babel is the apex of arrogance. It involves the harnessing of all humanity for a single purpose devised by a totalitarian regime, with all the means it can muster. [Genesis 11 contains] an intrinsic textual scorn for the robotization of the Babylonians. They share not only one language but also uniform concepts. All the energies are mobilized for the construction of monuments to their own glory ... This and the likeness of the material used in Babylon and by the Pharaohs for the erection of pyramids ... bring the Bible to condemn equally the Babylonian and Egyptian megalomania. As a symbol of this, the tower plays a major role."

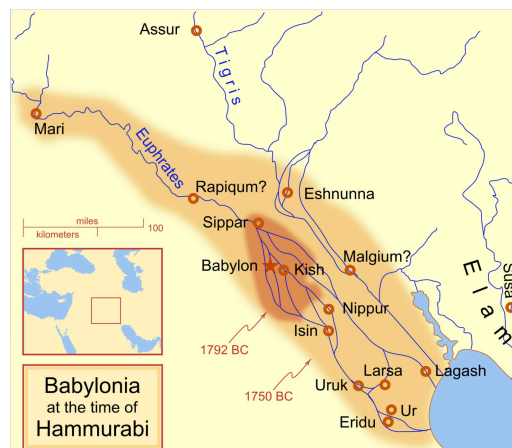
LaCocque, Andre (2010). [*The Captivity of Innocence: Babel and the Yahwist*](#). Wipf and Stock. 17, 19.

"In the late third millennium the ziggurat was developed by creating a succession of massive platforms on top of which a small shrine was located. This ziggurat was situated either adjacent to the main temple, or at a distance, but then connected to the temple by a succession of courtyards. It towered over the rest of the city, and must have presented an impressive sight, considering that the authors of the Biblical book of Genesis saw in Babylon's ziggurat a prime example of man's hubris."

Van De Mieroop, Marc (1999). [*The Ancient Mesopotamian City*](#). Oxford University Press. 77.

The Tower of Babylon in Ancient Near Eastern Perspective

Babylon's long early period (*Bab-il* = "gate of the gods" in Akkadian) culminated in the reign of Hammurabi (1795-1750 B.C.E.), who unified the entire Mesopotamian region under Babylon's rule. His reign was followed by a long decline until the Hittite uprising in 1595 B.C.E. It was nearly 1,000 years later that Nebuchadnezzar led the Neo-Babylonian empire to its resurgence in the late 600s B.C.E., which lasted less than a century because it fell to the Persians in 539 B.C.E.

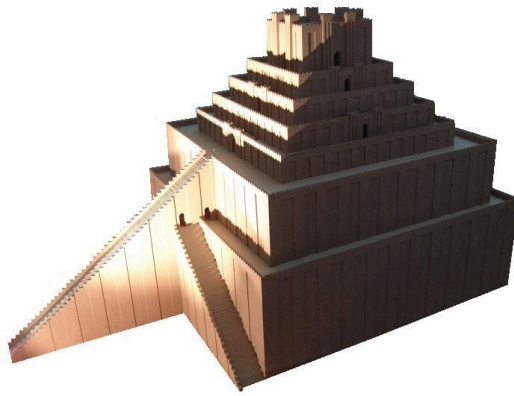


Map Master (2008). [Wikipedia](#)

The plains of Shinar refer to the huge river deltas of the Tigris and Euphrates which merge together before running into the Persian Gulf.

The great Etemenanki Ziggurat in Babylon, and the accompanying Esagila temple, was one of the largest temple structures in the ancient world. It was built, remodeled, and rebuilt several times within the 700 years

between the 14th and 7th century B.C.E.



Mustafin, O. (2006) [Wikipedia Commons](#)

Etemenanki is Sumerian for “tower of the foundation of Heaven and Earth.” Its 14th century origins are mentioned in the famous Babylonian epic of creation, Enuma Elish, which tells of Marduk’s rise to power as the old Babylonian empire came to dominate Mesopotamia in the 1200s B.C.E.

Enuma Elish

"The Anunna-gods, of heaven and earth, made ready to speak,
To Marduk their lord they said,
"Now, Lord, you who have liberated us,
(50) What courtesy may we do you?

**We will make a shrine, whose name will be a famous saying,
Your chamber that shall be our stopping place, we shall find rest therein ..."**

(55) When Marduk heard this,
His features glowed brightly, like the day,
"Then make Babylon the task that you requested,
Let its brickwork be formed, build high the shrine."

The Anunna-gods set to with hoes,

(60) One (full) year **they made its bricks**.

When the second year came, They raised up Esagila, the counterpart to the deep-waters,
They built **the high ziggurat ...**

For Anu-Enlil-Ea they founded his ... and dwelling.

(65) Majestically he took his seat before them,
Its pinnacles were facing toward the base of Esharra ...

(70) The Lord, on the Exalted Dais, which **they built as his dwelling**,

Seated the gods his fathers for a banquet,

"This is Babylon, your place of dwelling.

Take your pleasure there, seat yourselves in its delights!"

The great gods sat down,

(75) They set out cups, they sat down at the feast."

After they had taken their enjoyment inside it,
And in awe-inspiring Esagila had conducted the offering,
All the orders and designs had been made permanent,
All the gods had divided the stations of heaven and netherworld,
(80) The fifty great gods took their thrones,
The seven gods of destinies were confirmed forever for rendering judgment ...

After Anu had ordained the destinies of the bow,
He set out the royal throne which stood highest among the gods,
Anu had him sit there, in the assembly of the gods.
(95) Then the great gods convened,
They made Marduk's destiny highest, they prostrated themselves ...

They granted him exercise of kingship over the gods,
(100) They established him forever for lordship of heaven and earth.

Enuma Elish, Tablet 6. Quoted in Hallo, William W. and Younger, K. Lawson (2002). *The Context of Scripture: Volume 1 Canonical Compositions from the Biblical World*. Brill Academic Publishers. 401.



DKFindOut (2023) [Joel Edmund Anderson](#)

The temple and ziggurat were restored under the reign of Nabopolassar of the Neo-Babylonian empire in the 600s B.C.E. A cylindrical clay monument describes the remodel.

“At that time my lord Marduk told me in regard to Etemenanki, **the ziqqurraṭ of Babylon, to ground its foundation in the lap of the underworld, to make its summit like the heavens.** I fashioned pick-axes, spades and brick-moulds ... and set them in the hands of a vast workforce enlisted from my land. **I had them shape mud bricks without number and mould baked bricks like countless raindrops. I had the River Arakhtu bear asphalt and bitumen like a mighty flood ...**

Through the sagacity of Ea, through the intelligence of Marduk, through the wisdom of Nabû and Nissaba, by means of the vast mind that the god who created me let me possess, I deliberated with my great intellect, I commissioned the wisest experts ... The master-builders drew taut the measuring cords, they determined the limits. I sought confirmation by consulting Shamash, Adad and Marduk and, whenever my mind deliberated (and) I pondered (unsure of) the dimensions, the great gods made (the truth) known to me by the procedure of (oracular) confirmation ...

I constructed the building ... and **raised its top as high as a mountain.** For my lord Marduk I made it an object fitting for wonder, just as it was in former times.”

Nabopolassar Cylinder A, 1.30-3.37, Translation by George, A. R. (2005). *The Tower of Babel: Archaeology, History and Cuneiform Texts*. Archiv Für Orientforschung. 51, 75-95.

"The best indication of the function of the ziggurats comes from the names given to them. For instance, the name of the ziggurat at Babylon, Etemenanki, means 'temple of the foundation of heaven and earth.' One at Larsa means 'temple which links heaven and earth.' Most significant is the name of the ziggurat at Sippar, 'temple of the stairway to pure heaven' ... This stairway was a visual representation of that which was believed to be used by the gods to travel from one realm to another. It was solely for the convenience of the gods and was maintained in order to provide the deity with the amenities that would refresh him along the way ... At the top of the ziggurat was the gate of the gods, the entrance into their heavenly abode. At the bottom was the temple, where hopefully the god would descend to receive the gifts and worship of his people. A similar mentality concerning location can be seen among the settlers of the American West, who picked up their towns and moved them into proximity with the newly laid railroad tracks, then erected a train station so that the train would stop there and bring economic benefits. In summary, the Tower of Babel project is a temple complex featuring a ziggurat, which was designed to make it convenient for the god to come down to his temple, receive worship from the people, and bless them."

Walton, John H. (2001). [*Genesis: The NIV Application Commentary*](#). Zondervan Academic. 374.

"The tower of Babel story is ... a spoof on ancient beliefs about the Mecca of Mesopotamia, the Esagil. The temple of Marduk in Babylon was supposed to have been built by the ... gods with specially prepared bricks. Its name, 'house with the uplifted head,' reflects its claim to have reached the heavens. But Genesis unmercifully batters these claims ... As for its vaunted height, so far short of heaven did this so-called skyscraper fall that God could hardly see it: he had to come down to look at it! But though man's highest achievement was pathetic in God's eyes, the motives that prompted his efforts were horrific. The desire to displace God from heaven, to make a name for oneself rather than allow God to do this, and to scheme without reference to his declared will, prompts one final judgment that will hobble man's attempts at cooperate rebellion once and for all ... The name 'Babel/Babylon' does not mean 'gate of the god,' as the Babylonians held, but 'confusion,' and it evokes the similar sounding words 'folly' (*nabal*) and 'flood' (*mabul*). Far from being the last word in human culture, it is the ultimate symbol of man's failure when he attempts to go it alone in defiance of his creator."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [*Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 1: Genesis 1-15*](#). Thomas Nelson. 172-173.

"Babel as a name solicits our attention ... for it means 'the gate of the divine' ... This empire's ultimate achievement is a tower, a rigid monument erected upwards as a channel of communication with the divine, with a guaranteed stability and permanence. From an Israelite perspective, the tower is an assault on the divine, because it is linked with a religious illusion. God is not reached by any human construct; he comes down by choice and establishes relations by covenanting with people. He is not the God of Etemenanki, but of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob."

LaCocque, Andre (2010). [*The Captivity of Innocence: Babel and the Yahwist*](#). Wipf and Stock. 14.

Reversal of Babylon in the Prophets

The prophet Zephaniah hopes that one day Babylon will be reversed and Yahweh's justice will result in restoration and renewal for all nations.

[Zephaniah 3:8-9](#) is the hinge.

- Yahweh's justice is a purification process (3:9) to unify the nations in worship of the one true God (cf. 2:11) as a reversal of Genesis 11.
- Jerusalem and its remnant will be restored (3:10-20).

Zephaniah 3:8 NRSV*

For my decision (משפט) is to gather (קבץ) the nations, to assemble kingdoms, to pour out on them my wrath (זעם), all the heat of my anger (חרון אפי)

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This verse is hyperlinked to Joel 3:2 and Nahum 1:6

Joel 3:2 NASB*

I will gather (קבץ) all nations ... and enter into judgment (משפט) with them

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Nahum 1:6 NRSV*

Before his wrath (זעם), who can stand?
And who can arise in the heat of his anger (חרון אפיו)?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Zephaniah 3:9-10 NASB*

For then I will transform/turn over for peoples
a pure lip (שפה + ברר),
so that all of them can call upon the name of Yahweh (קרא בשם יהוה)
to serve him with one (אחד) shoulder;
from across the rivers of Cush,
my worshippers (עתרי),
the daughter of my scattering (פוז),
they will carry (יבל) my offering.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This verse is hyperlinked to Genesis 11:1, 6-7, 9; and Isaiah 18:1, 7

Genesis 11:1, 6-7, 9 Instructor's Translation

¹And all the land had one lip (שפה אחד) ... ⁶“Behold, they are one people (עם אחד), with one lip (שפה אחת) ...
⁷ come, let us confuse their lip (שפה + בלל) ... so Yahweh scattered (פוז) them ... therefore its name is called
Babylon (בבל), for there Yahweh confused the lip (בלל שפה) of all the land.

Isaiah 18:1, 7 Instructor's Translation

¹... from across the rivers of Cush ... ⁷ a people tall and dark will carry (יבל) tribute to Yahweh

"Zephaniah 3:8-10 combines multiple themes. The violent face divine justice, not to destroy them, but to purify them, so that they can be reconciled to Yahweh (see Joel 3 and Nahum 1). This theme is combined with the restoration of Jerusalem, which is viewed as an 'anti-Babylon.' By alluding to Genesis 11:1-9 and the story of the tower of Babel, Zephaniah 3:9-10 portrays the restoration of Zion as the undoing of the human dispersion. Rather than the tower of Babylon, Jerusalem operates as the center of a new humanity unified in worship of Yahweh with a purified language."

Nogalski, J. (2013). "Zephaniah's Use of Genesis 1-11." *Hebrew Bible and Ancient Israel*, 2 (3). 351-372.

Reflection Question

In Genesis, what does the building of cities represent? What are city builders trying to accomplish?